

Selective Visibility And A Modern Approach To The Study Of Stage Lighting In Students' Performance Of Don Pedro Obaseki's *Azagidi*

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Abstract

Stage lighting is the art of deploying available technology (lighting instruments) towards achieving the goals of a performance. It plays an important role in establishing the mood, aesthetics, as well as style of the production. However, selective visibility which is a core function and application of stage lighting has not enjoyed the deserved scholarship in Nigeria. As a result, this study intends to fill the vacuum in literature by examining how selective visibility was applied to the production of a Nigerian play leading to the creation of special effects, and support of the narrative structure of performance. The study is descriptive and the research instrument for the collection of data is the video recording of the performance to assess the effectiveness of lighting in guiding audience perception, shaping dramatic tension, and reinforcing thematic elements. The study adopts the social learning theory of Albert Bandura and formalistic approach of analysis. The findings of this study reveal that, selective visibility in Azagidi controlled audience focus by isolating acting areas, enhanced the mood through color and intensity and supported storytelling by emphasizing dramatic moments. The study recommends that selective visibility should be adopted as a relevant technique of stage lighting. It concludes that selective visibility is a powerful tool for theatrical performances.

Introduction

Stage is vital to theatre. The important aspect in stage design for productions in

theatre is the light for the stage as all the performances are characterized by it. Stage lighting allows visibility to all the spectators, models shape to the person that designed and influences insight by the viewers. However, perception is personal in stage lighting. When done properly, it upsurges how the audience understand the play. It is however important to note that the primary function of stage lighting is visibility, its other functions include artistic configuration, stage atmosphere effects and diversification in the exposure of forms (Sokari, 20) Lighting of the theatre stage can be carried out in diverse ways including: area, general, offstage and sky lighting (Asomba, 117). Stage lighting is the art of positioning available technology (in the form of lighting instruments) towards accomplishing the goals of a performance. It plays a crucial role in establishing the mood, aesthetics, as well as style of the production. In essence, the following are the major controllable qualities of stage light which designers control to create visibility and special effects on stage: intensity, distribution, direction, quality, colour and movement.

Literature Review

Stage lighting is far more than the simple act of banishing darkness. It is a powerful, non-verbal language that shapes narrative, guides emotion, and defines space. For centuries, lighting designers have wielded this tool based on a foundational framework often broken down into five key aspects: Visibility, Mood, Composition, Revelation of Form, and Reinforcement of the Plot. Yet, within the very first and most fundamental of these aspects_ Visibility is a sophisticated and critically under-examined sub-discipline:

Selective visibility.

As technology and theatrical storytelling evolve, there is a pressing need for dedicated academic and practical research into this nuanced craft. While some studies have been conducted on Selective visibility in stage lighting, the foremost of which was brought forward in Stanley McCandless' *A Method of Lighting the Stage*. Its claim is that "The eye is naturally drawn to the brightest area and that a designer must manipulate this instinct" (McCandless 23) Jean Rosenthal applied the principle for deep dramatic and psychological effect. In her work, *The Magic of Light*, she treated light as an active storytelling element. She famously stated that her goal was to make the audience "see what you want them to see, and to *not see* what you don't want them to see" (Rosenthal 45). However, none of these works has

isolated selective visibility in stage lighting as a stand-alone technique of lighting the stage, separate from the visibility function of stage lighting. This is the gap which this research seeks to fill.

Selective Visibility in Stage Lighting

Selective visibility is the utilizing of stage lights in a way and manner that makes it possible for the members of the audience to perceive exactly what is intended for them to see, how the director wants them to see the particular player or action on stage and why it is intended. It is an act of forcing the audience to look at a particular space by manipulating the natural human tendencies to direct their attention to the brighter areas and to look away from darkness which they instinctively perceived as foreboding and evil.

The fundamental principle for selective visibility is that: 'Each member of the audience must be able to see clearly and correctly those things that he or she is intended to see'. This rule ties invariably, the essence of selective visibility solely to the intent of the director and lighting designer. The parts of the stage such as off stage areas to which the audience's attention should not be drawn should be left in complete darkness, or lit less brightly.

During the action of the play, different parts of the stage may become more important, different actors may need to appear more dominant. So, the balance of visibility may be changed, either subtly or sharply. The balance of lighting may move from one side of the stage to another; an actor in an important speech may be gradually highlighted. In this way, the lighting acts as a pointer to the audience, telling them where to look (Pilbrow, 7).

The word 'Selectivity' can be adapted to explain the same lighting concept, and selectivity in stage lighting can be likened to how film and television directors use cameras to select the exact part of the action that they wish the audience to focus on at any given moment. By zooming and cutting from one camera to another, they can select any breadth of vision from a wide panorama to a close-up of a pore on an individual's skin:

In theatre, the audience normally has the whole stage within their angle of vision all the time. To focus attention on a particular area, the director can use light. The obvious technique is to light only the selected areas of the stage while

the rest is blacked out. However, it is also possible to make a subtle but positive selection of vision by balancing the selected area to a brighter level than the rest of the stage. It is surprising how even the smallest light re-balance can help to focus audience attention on the appropriate action area. (Reid, 14)

To utilize selective visibility is to deliberately use light and darkness to create focal points on stage. While stage left may be dark, the right part of the stage should be visible to the house. It is ludicrous to have a total blackout on stage at any time during the performance since selective visibility has made it possible to divide the stage and have different scenes at different parts of the stage.

Selective visibility establishes focus. "To see what should be seen" may mean revealing the mere silhouette of a three-dimensional form, the solidity of its mass, or the full decorative and textural detail of all surfaces. Although visibility certainly relies on intensity, contrast also plays a significant role in achieving good stage visibility. (Wolf, 318)

Michael Gillette, employs the term 'Selective Focus' to explain this technique. He opined that:

Selective focus means directing the spectators' attention to a specific place. The lighting designer can selectively focus attention on a number of ways, but the primary method is by manipulating our instinctive response to light. Everybody has a strong instinct to look at an area of brightness or movement in an otherwise neutral scene. By simply making one part of the stage brighter than the rest of the set, the lighting designer forces the spectators to look there (Gillette, 289).

Selective visibility is one of the visual tools utilized during the process of actualizing the director's intentions in a performance.

Trends of Stage Lighting in Nigeria and the Advent of Selective Visibility

In most places in Nigeria, early theatre practice started from outdoor rituals and festivals. Contemporary Nigerian theatre, however, evolved out of its ceremonious and sacred origins to take up the purpose of entertainment. A good example of these evolved theatre forms is the Yoruba travelling theatre form called the "Alarinjo". Alarinjo theatre had its roots in the traditional rites of the Egungun (masquerade) festivals of the Western part of the country, but soon got detached from its ritual origins. With the traditional performance

outdoor and mostly open-air space, there was no need for artificial forms of lighting as the natural source of light; the sun or aided with native lamps served the basic function of illumination during the day, and at night, the moon provided light and traditional clay lamps were carried during the night rituals to help the visibility of the spectators. (Oshodi, 10).

The advent of the British colonizers and the introduction of the English Language exposed Nigerians to other forms of entertainment. The emergence of the other forms of entertainment in the late 19th century resulted in the shift from the traditional form of entertainment to the more European-inspired one of concerts, especially among the educated urban dwellers.' (Oni, 86)

Complex artificial lighting emerged with these colonial influences on entertainment and theatrical performance. (Oshodi, 43). The earliest documented modern and indoor theatre attempts in Nigeria are said to have been organized by church groups and staged in churches and school halls in the Western cities of Abeokuta, Ibadan and Lagos.

The first recorded use of indoor stage lighting in Nigeria predated the introduction of electricity in the country. Oni stated that two kinds of lamps: 'suspending' and 'Chinese' lamps were used in lighting performances. Contrary to what they sounded like, these lamps were not specialized theatre lights. Suspended lamps were in fact, not different from the lamps people used for lighting their homes. They were lamps that produced illumination from burning colza and paraffin as energy sources. (Oni, 89). The limitation of these lamps however, was that they did not produce sufficient brightness, and the audience complained largely of poor visibility.

According to Ayamolowo et al, electricity was introduced to Nigeria in 1896, and by 1901, it had been installed in Glover Hall, a newly built public hall which later became the hub of theatrical performances and other entertainment forms in the twentieth century Lagos. The introduction of electricity however, did not instantly revolutionize stage lighting in Nigeria.

Most of the performances were still lit by candles, kerosene, gas, palm oil and colza. This was due mainly to the high cost of electricity and its unreliable nature. On certain occasions that electricity was used, as was the case in the

stage presentation designed by the energetic and enterprising Mr. Jones, the stage lighting was said to have complemented the general aesthetics of the presentation. (Oni, 93)

Theatrical activities in most of the parts of the world witnessed a massive decline during the First World War (1914 – 1918), and Nigeria was not an exception. This period of fear and uncertainty lingered even after the war had ended. This compelled a lot of secular entertainers to retrace their steps back into the church. Documented theatrical activities of the time included African adaptations of European-styled cantatas, commonly tagged “Service of Songs”. These productions afforded upcoming actors a platform for exposure before a growing audience centered on church activities and events. Since these church productions had limited access to sufficient lighting technology in their venues, stage lighting in Nigeria took a couple of steps back from experimentation and aesthetics. It took up only the basic function of simple illumination.

From 1945 to 1976, there was a change in the tide of theatrical performances in Nigeria; Artists such as Kola Ogunmola, Duro Ladipo, Hubert Ogunde, and Moses Olaiya came into lime light with their Yoruba Travelling Theatre groups. Hubert Ogunde was particularly known for his contribution to the area of stage lighting in Nigeria as he was, among his contemporaries the only one that had access to novel stage lighting technologies. His access to these technologies was largely due to the fact that he staged so many performances in Lagos. For instance, his very first native opera *The Garden of Eden* and *The Throne of God* were first staged (on 12th June, 1944), in the Glover Memorial Hall, Lagos.

“...this gave Ogunde the opportunity to provide stage lighting variety for the music and dance aspects that required colourful lights as well as the dramatic actions that required more realistic lighting”. (Oni, 95).

Ogunde's quest for perfection kept him on his toes and his innovativeness made him stand out. He acquired and deployed modern lighting, sound and scenery equipment for his productions. Ogunde's lighting styles involved an appropriate use of the colour red alongside musical instruments, while colourful lights were used to herald him on stage. He also had his face lit up by two narrow-beam spotlights while he sang. He believed his face was the main focal point of the show, hence the special attention to

spotlighting it. This act counts as the earliest record of the use of selective visibility in stage lighting in the Nigerian scene.

The Yoruba Travelling Theatre groups soon began to venture into film production. Surprisingly, this new-found Art form did not immediately push their live performances into obscurity. In fact, they co-existed for a while. Moses Olaiya's troupe for instance, would start off their shows with a film show and end the show with a live performance. This style necessitated the need to control the intensity of stage lights; keeping them low for the film show, and having the stage brightly lit for the drama. So, Moses Olaiya came up with a control mechanism where switches were mounted on a board. This was the advent of locally-made dimmers in the Nigerian stage lighting scene.

The performance venues for the Yoruba travelling theatre groups ranged from Arts Council Halls, to University and privately-owned theatres. One thing common to these venues was that they had limited stage lighting equipment. Consequently, these troupes had to use their own (equally limited) facilities. These equipments were mainly floodlights used with colour gels and a couple of special effect lights. These colour gels were used to establish mood in dramatic performances. Red was used for supernatural scenes and war, green established forest scenes, while blue signified night and was also used for love scenes.

Because of their involvement in the novel Art of filmmaking, the Yoruba travelling theatre groups were opened up to new possibilities in stage lighting. Beyond the use of floodlights, ultra-violet lights, switches and locally made dimmers, they adopted advanced dimmers, spot lights and control equipment. The most notable of this movement was Ogunde's use of the Strand Pattern 252 fire effect to portray a hell fire scene in his play, *Aropin Nt'enia*.

The establishment of Departments of Theatre Arts and Centres for Cultural/ African Studies in Nigerian universities, as well as the establishment of state government Art Councils led to an influx of advanced stage lighting equipment into the country. Professionals in the field were employed and one of them was Kingsley William Dexter Lindersay, a technical director who trained the very first set of theatre technicians in Nigeria. Lindersay worked at the University of Ibadan, Ibadan from 1966 to 1972, Ahmadu Bello University,

Zaria from 1972 to 1974, University of Calabar, Calabar (1976 – 1983) and Cross River State University, Uyo between 1983 and 1985. He was said to have purchased most of the stage lighting equipment acquired in the country, during this period of two decades.

In 1977, Nigeria hosted the World Black Festival of Arts and Culture (FESTAC '77). This historic event opened up new possibilities in the area of stage lighting in Nigeria, as well as the entertainment scene at large. Prior to FESTAC '77, Nigerian lighting designers only operated within the context of Nigerian University theatres. However, after this remarkable event, theatre Arts in Nigeria witnessed a collaborative evolution, where artists and technicians in the area of lights, sets, costume and sound worked as professionals, each handling his or her area towards the common goal of the oftentimes professional performances. It is important to note that in 1976, the National Theatre of Nigeria was opened at Iganmu, Lagos in preparation for the FESTAC '77 and was adequately equipped with such lighting equipment as fresnels, spot lights, flood lights and a 99-cue memory lighting board. This theatre afforded Nigerian theatre artists the opportunity to practise outside of the walls of the university.

Post- FESTAC '77 Lagos also witnessed a remarkable shift from theatrical lighting to advanced concert lighting as more establishments took interest in staging musical entertainment events, due to the large audience turnout (and consequently revenue generation) witnessed by these types of shows. One of the propagators of this new movement was Dapo Adelegan who organised Lekki Sunsplash, a yearly package of musical concerts that featured famous Nigerian music artistes and an array of dazzling lights. These events attracted the investment and partnership of multi-national companies, including the SevenUp Bottling Company and led to the importation of newer lighting instruments, which has been described as “Hi – tech, energetic and highly creative”.

These special effect lights like the Roboscan 1220, Robozap MSR 1200, Robocolor Mobile, Series Sweepers helped to increase the audience number as they served as another source of attraction to them. The impact of this is also felt amongst the lighting designers of this time; the theatre lighting designers found this massive concert lighting more lucrative compared to the dramatic

performance; this could be ascribed to the high rate of sponsorship and remuneration that comes with it, thereby leading to emerging lighting equipment companies: The New Culture Studios, Aibtonia, and DSV (Durolights, Sound and Vision) Ltd. Zmirage Multimedia Ltd., Dolphin Studios, Captain George's Strong tower Gold-Myne Int. Limited, Total Consult and other new generation lighting outfits like Ultima Studio.(Ojo, 38)

In 1994, the Music Society of Nigeria opened the Muson Centre at Onikan, Lagos and two halls (Agip Recital Hall and Shell Hall) were fully furnished with stage lighting equipment as profile spotlights, prism convex spotlights, as well as 500W floodlights. It became a trend for institutions to install lighting equipment in their halls, as a form of investment. The use of new modern lighting technology eventually spread to the theatrical lighting scene. An instance of this is seen in some productions that took over the 90's; *Sikulu* and *Langbodo* during which advanced lighting effects were used. In the university space, Alphonsus Orisaremi, a lighting designer who previously worked as the pioneer lighting designer at the Africa Independent Television (AIT), also introduced these modern (and largely digital) lighting equipment into the Theatre Arts Department of the University of Ibadan, Ibadan, Nigeria.

Theoretical Framework: Selective Visibility

Selective visibility is rooted in the principle that lighting should expose only what the director intends the audience to see. Richard Pilbrow notes that lighting acts as an optical indicator, subtly or sharply shifting focus across the stage to focus on key actions or actors. This technique mirrors cinematic close-ups, where the camera controls viewers' attention. In theatre, lighting achieves a similar effect by controlling brightness, contrast and shadow.

Theoretical Framework: Social Learning Theory

This theory holds that people can learn new behaviours simply by observing others. It argues that "Learning is an internal process that can occur without direct reinforcement through the observation of models"(45) It also demonstrates that learning and performance are distinct. (Bandura and Walters, 72). One of the real world applications of this theory is in the study of stage lighting. Here, the instructor or lecturer acts as a model, demonstrating how the dimmer board, lighting instruments are deployed to achieve the goals of visibility and selective visibility in a performance. The students are also

distributed into small performance and technical theatre groups which give room for collaborative learning as each technical theatre student takes turn being the model in how he appropriates stage lighting to suit the artistic and production goals of his performance group.

Synopsis of *Azagidi*

The play is a tragedy that addresses greed, ambition and revenge. A well-known warrior decides to conquer the earth until he is met with strong opposition from Igbahon, daughter of the sea god and her maidens. The outcome of the battle was a truce and marriage between Azagidi and herself. Upon his return to his hometown, the blessings of the sea god's daughter made him successful in all his ventures and within a short time the couple became successful farmers and they gave birth to children who would inherit their wealth after them. In another development, Azagidi suddenly finds himself in a nerve wracking situation when the king's only daughter; the princess requests for his hand in marriage, in spite of his being a married man with two children from his wife, Igbahon. Despite being a valiant warrior and a successful farmer, his ambition for inheriting the throne gets in the way of his loyalty to his wife and her blind revenge causes more havoc than the initial bargain.

Results and Findings

Appraisal of Stage Lighting in students' performance of the play *Azagidi*

Stage lighting is a complex aspect of the theatre arts that requires a comprehensive process beginning from installation to operation. Operation is advised to be carried out by professionals only and the training received by final year students who specialize generally in Technical Theatre is sufficient in helping them surmount the challenges associated with the task of lighting for the theatre stage. These students are required as part of the course requirements to create a standard and viable lighting plot, practical cue sheets and improvise should there be a challenge of insufficient lights that may occur in the eventuality of burnt lamps. Adequate stage lighting positions such as backlighting, front-of-house lighting and area lighting are also to be mastered by such students of the technical theatre.